RSE-HB-01 — Employee Handbook & Code of Conduct

FICTIONAL — for demonstration only

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1 About This Handbook

1.1 Purpose

This handbook explains how Ridgeline Structural Engineering, Inc. ("Ridgeline") works: who we are, the standards of conduct we expect, how to raise a concern and who can see your HR records. It is the starting point for every other Ridgeline policy, and it points to them rather than repeating them. Ridgeline is a fictional company, and this handbook is FICTIONAL — for demonstration only. Nothing in it is HR or legal advice.

The handbook is written for everyone at Ridgeline, from new graduates on their first project site to directors who approve requests for their teams. It is deliberately short. Each section gives the rule in plain words and then points to the policy that owns the detail, so you can find the full answer without reading every document. If something you need isn't covered here or in another policy, ask the HR Service Desk rather than guessing: a question asked early is always easier to answer than a problem fixed later.

1.2 Who it applies to

This handbook applies to every Ridgeline employee: full-time, part-time and interns. Contractors are not employees. A contractor is bound only by the Code of Conduct (§4), Health and Safety (§5), Reporting Concerns (§6) and the Information Security & Acceptable Use policy (RSE-SEC-01). Every other matter for a contractor, including time off, pay, benefits and working arrangements, is governed by their contract or agency. Contractors with questions about those matters should contact their agency or Ridgeline contract manager. Ridgeline's other HR policies do not apply to contractors.

Managers who work with contractors should make sure the contractor knows which Ridgeline rules bind them: how to behave at work, how to stay safe on site, how to raise a concern and how to handle Ridgeline information and systems. Requests from contractors about anything else, such as taking time off or working from another location, are not decided by the contractor's Ridgeline manager under Ridgeline policy; they are settled under the contractor's own contract, through their agency or Ridgeline contract manager.

1.3 How Ridgeline policies fit together

Ridgeline keeps one policy per topic, and each document owns its own rules. The current set of policies is: RSE-HB-01 Employee Handbook & Code of Conduct; RSE-PTO-01 Paid Time Off Policy; RSE-HOL-01 Holiday Calendar & Observance; RSE-LV-01 Leave of Absence Policy; RSE-RW-01 Remote & Hybrid Work Policy; RSE-LOC-01 Work Location, Travel & Cross-Border Work Guidelines; RSE-SEC-01 Information Security & Acceptable Use; RSE-EXP-01 Travel & Expense Reimbursement; RSE-BEN-01 Benefits Summary & Eligibility; RSE-EQ-01 Equipment & Home-Office Stipend; RSE-ONB-01 Onboarding Procedures; and RSE-APR-01 Approval Matrix. Where two documents touch the same subject, one states the rule and the other points to it.

For example, the number of PTO days you earn is stated only in the Paid Time Off Policy; the Onboarding Procedures mention PTO but point back to it. The approvers for every kind of request are stated only in the Approval Matrix; other policies name the approver for convenience and point to the matrix as the reference. If you ever find two documents that seem to disagree, tell the HR Service Desk so the wording can be corrected, and follow the document that owns the topic until it is.

1.4 Changes and versions

This is version 2026.1 of the handbook, effective 2026-01-01. HR reviews the handbook every year and publishes changes in the HR Portal with a new version number. The version in the HR Portal is always the one that applies. If a printed or downloaded copy differs from the HR Portal, the HR Portal wins.

When a policy changes, HR summarises what changed and why, and gives notice before the change takes effect wherever it can. Requests already approved under an earlier version, such as approved PTO or an approved remote-work arrangement, are not undone by a later change unless HR tells you otherwise.

2 Ridgeline at a Glance

2.1 Offices

Ridgeline is a civil and structural engineering consultancy with about 450 people. We have four offices. Denver, Colorado is our headquarters (America/Denver time). Our other offices are Austin, Texas (America/Chicago), Seattle, Washington (America/Los_Angeles) and Toronto, Ontario (America/Toronto). Your home office is the office on your HR record. It decides your holiday calendar (RSE-HOL-01 §1.1) and your local core hours.

Each office runs its own projects but shares engineering standards, tools and teams across the firm. It is common for a project team to include engineers from more than one office, which is why core hours (§3.2) and shared anchor days matter. Toronto staff follow the Canada holiday calendar; staff in Denver, Austin and Seattle follow the US calendar. Your home office stays the same when you travel or work temporarily from somewhere else.

2.2 Employment Types

Every person at Ridgeline has one Employment Type on their HR record. Full-time, exempt employees work a standard 40-hour week. Full-time, non-exempt (hourly) employees also work 40 hours a week, record their time, and need written pre-approval for overtime (§3.3). Part-time employees are scheduled for 20 to 29 hours a week. Interns join for a fixed internship of no more than 6 months. Contractors are engaged through a contract or agency, are not employees, and are covered only as described in §1.2. Ridgeline's HR policies apply to full-time, part-time and intern employees.

Your Employment Type affects many of your entitlements: how much PTO you earn, which benefits you can join, whether you record your hours and whether you can claim a home-office stipend. Each policy says which Employment Types it covers in its header block. You can see your own Employment Type in the HR Portal. If you think it is recorded wrongly, contact the HR Service Desk.

2.3 Work Arrangements

Each employee has one Work Arrangement. Office-hybrid is the default: you work from your home office on set anchor days and remotely on the others. Remote-approved employees work remotely most of the time, with approval from their manager and HR. Field/site-based employees work at project sites and are not eligible for remote work. The Remote & Hybrid Work Policy (RSE-RW-01) sets out the rules for each arrangement.

Your Work Arrangement is part of your HR record and is agreed when you join. It can change, for

example when an office-hybrid employee is approved to become remote-approved, or when a field/site-based employee moves into a design role. Changes are requested through the HR Portal and approved as set out in the Approval Matrix.

2.4 Managers, directors and approvers

Your manager is the direct manager on your HR record. Your director is your manager's director. Many requests need a particular approver: your manager, your director, HR or the VP Finance. The Approval Matrix (RSE-APR-01) lists who approves what, and it is the single place those approvers are defined.

Managers and directors also have responsibilities beyond approving requests. They make sure their teams know the policies that apply to them, respond to requests promptly, keep personal information about their team members confidential, and pass concerns raised with them to HR when a concern is serious or sensitive. A manager who is unsure how to handle a request should ask the HR Service Desk before deciding.

3 Working Hours

3.1 Standard week

Ridgeline's standard working week is 40 hours, Monday to Friday. Project schedules sometimes need different hours; agree any regular change to your hours with your manager.

Site work can start early or run late, especially during pours, inspections and deliveries. Field/site-based employees follow the site's working hours, agreed in advance with their manager. Take regular breaks, and don't work long stretches without rest; tired people make mistakes, and on a site mistakes can be dangerous.

3.2 Core hours

Everyone is expected to be available during core hours, 10:00–15:00 in their local time zone, so that teams across our offices can meet. Outside core hours you may arrange your day with your manager and team. Core hours apply whether you are in the office or working remotely.

Because our offices span several time zones, a meeting inside core hours in Toronto may be early in Seattle. Teams that work across offices should agree meeting times that fall within everyone's core hours where possible, and rotate inconvenient times fairly when they can't.

3.3 Time recording and overtime (non-exempt)

Non-exempt (hourly) employees record all hours worked in the HR Portal. Overtime must be pre-approved in writing by the manager before it is worked. If urgent site work makes advance approval impossible, tell your manager as soon as you can and record the hours accurately.

All hours worked must be recorded and paid, including time spent travelling to a site during the working day and time spent on required training. Never work "off the clock", and managers must never ask anyone to.

3.4 Part-time schedules

A part-time employee's schedule is agreed in writing with the manager and recorded in the HR Portal. The agreed schedule sets your scheduled working days, which matter for holidays (RSE-HOL-01 §1.4) and for pro-rated PTO and benefits.

4 Code of Conduct

4.1 Respect and anti-harassment

Ridgeline prohibits harassment, discrimination and bullying of any kind. Examples of prohibited conduct include unwelcome comments or jokes about a person's accent, ethnicity, religion, gender, age, disability or appearance; repeated belittling in meetings; unwanted physical contact; and offensive messages or images. This applies in the office, on project sites, at client premises, at work events and online. If you experience or witness conduct like this, you can raise it through any route in §6, and you will be protected from retaliation (§6.3).

What matters is the effect of the conduct, not the intention behind it. A remark meant as a joke can still be harassment if it is unwelcome and demeaning, and a pattern of small remarks can be as serious as a single incident. Everyone at Ridgeline is expected to treat colleagues, clients and site workers with respect, to speak up when they see behaviour that crosses the line, and to support colleagues who raise a concern. Managers who become aware of possible harassment must make sure HR knows about it, even if the person affected has not made a formal report.

4.2 Conflicts of interest

Avoid situations where your personal interests could conflict, or appear to conflict, with Ridgeline's or a client's interests. Examples include a financial interest in a supplier, a family member working for a bidder, or outside work for a competing firm. Disclose any possible conflict to your manager and HR as soon as you are aware of it, so it can be managed.

Most conflicts can be managed simply, for example by moving a decision to a colleague or by recording the disclosure on the project file. A conflict that is disclosed is rarely a problem; a conflict that is hidden and later discovered can damage Ridgeline's reputation with clients and lead to action under the HR process.

4.3 Gifts and hospitality

You may accept modest gifts and ordinary business hospitality from clients and suppliers. Any gift or hospitality worth more than $100 must be declared to HR. Never accept cash, or anything offered in return for a decision, a contract or confidential information.

Be especially careful during a bid or procurement, when even a modest gift from a bidder can look like an attempt to influence the outcome; politely decline and tell your manager. Declare gifts through the HR Portal, describing the gift, who gave it and its approximate value. Giving gifts to clients is handled the same way, and client entertainment follows the Travel & Expense Reimbursement policy (RSE-EXP-01 §5.2).

4.4 Client confidentiality

Client drawings, models and project information are confidential. Handle them according to their data classification under the Information Security & Acceptable Use policy (RSE-SEC-01 §2), and share them only with people who need them for the project.

Don't discuss client projects in public places, on social media or with people outside Ridgeline unless the client has agreed. Your duty of confidentiality continues after a project ends and after you leave Ridgeline.

4.5 Professional licensure

Only licensed professional engineers may seal or sign engineering drawings and calculations, and only for work they have personally reviewed. Never use another engineer's seal or signature. Keep your own licence current; licence renewals are reimbursed under RSE-EXP-01 §7.2.

Engineers working toward licensure should work under the supervision of a licensed engineer and keep a record of their experience. Tell your manager straight away if your licence lapses or is restricted, so project responsibilities can be adjusted.

5 Health and Safety

5.1 Site safety and PPE

Personal protective equipment (PPE) is required on every project site: safety boots, hard hat, high-visibility clothing and safety glasses as the site requires. Follow the site's safety plan and the instructions of the site safety lead. Field/site-based employees can be reimbursed for PPE under RSE-EXP-01 §7.1.

Office staff who visit a site for a meeting or inspection must also wear the PPE the site requires; site teams keep spare equipment for visitors. You may stop work at any time if you believe it is unsafe, and you will never be penalised for doing so in good faith. Tell the site safety lead and your manager straight away so the hazard can be dealt with.

5.2 Incident reporting

Report every injury and near-miss to your manager and HR within 24 hours, even if no one was hurt. Reports help us fix hazards before they cause harm. In an emergency, get help first and report afterwards.

Use the incident form in the HR Portal, describing what happened, where, who was involved and what has been done to make the area safe. Don't include medical details beyond what is needed to describe the injury; HR will follow up privately with the person affected. Incident reports are reviewed so that lessons are shared across our project sites.

6 Reporting Concerns

6.1 How to report

If you have a concern about harassment, discrimination, retaliation, safety or any other breach of this handbook, you can raise it in whichever way you are most comfortable with. You can talk to your manager. You can contact the HR Service Desk at hr@ridgeline.example or through HR Portal > Ask HR. For sensitive matters, contact HR Confidential at hr-confidential@ridgeline.example, which only a small HR team can read. You can also call the ethics line on +1 555 0100, available 24/7, with an anonymous option. You never have to raise a concern with the person it is about.

When you raise a concern, say what happened, when and where, who was involved and whether anyone else saw it. You don't need proof, and you don't need to be certain that a rule was broken; it is enough that you have a genuine concern. If you prefer, HR can open an HR ticket for you in the HR Confidential queue, with only a minimal summary recorded, and contact you to discuss the details privately.

6.2 Confidentiality

Concerns are handled confidentially. Information is shared only with the people who need it to look into and resolve the concern, and HR tells you who that is where it can.

6.3 Non-retaliation

Ridgeline does not tolerate retaliation against anyone who raises a concern in good faith or takes part in an investigation. Retaliation is itself a breach of this handbook and is dealt with through the HR process. If you think you are being treated badly because you raised a concern, report it through any route in §6.1.

6.4 What happens next

HR acknowledges every concern within 2 working days. HR then looks into it, which may include talking to you, to witnesses and to the person concerned. When the review is finished, HR closes the loop with you and tells you what it can about the outcome.

While a concern is being looked into, HR may put temporary measures in place, such as changing meeting arrangements or reporting lines, to protect the people involved. These measures are not a finding against anyone. Some details of the outcome may stay confidential to protect the privacy of others, but HR will always tell you when the matter is closed and what you can do if a problem happens again.

7 Personal Data and Privacy

7.1 What HR holds about you

HR keeps the records needed to employ you: your profile (name, title, department, office, Employment Type, Work Arrangement, manager and hire date), your time-off balances, your benefits elections and any HR tickets you raise. Self-service tools such as the HR Portal show these records. They do not show pay or health details.

HR keeps records only as long as they are needed for employment, legal or contractual reasons, and protects them under the Information Security & Acceptable Use policy (RSE-SEC-01). Medical information you share with HR, for example about medical leave or an accommodation, is kept separately from your general HR record and is never shown to your manager.

7.2 Who can see your records

You can see all of your own records. Managers and directors can see the profile and time-off balance of people in their reporting chain, and can run the compliance check on their PTO requests. Your benefits elections and your HR tickets are private to you and HR. Nobody else can see your records. If you ask about someone else's records and you are not in their reporting chain, the answer is that the record can't be shared.

Access is based on who you are, not on who you say you are: tools that show HR records check the person signed in. Colleagues on the same team, peers and people in other reporting lines cannot see each other's records, even with good intentions. If a colleague asks you for information from their own record, point them to the HR Portal, where they can see it themselves.

7.3 Asking for your data

You can ask for a copy of the personal data HR holds about you, or ask for a correction, through the HR Service Desk.

Most of your information can be checked and updated yourself in the HR Portal, such as your contact details and emergency contacts. For anything you can't change yourself, HR will respond to your request as soon as it can and tell you if any information has to be withheld to protect someone else's privacy.

8 Acknowledgement

When you join, and whenever a new version is published, read this handbook and acknowledge it in the HR Portal. Ask the HR Service Desk if anything is unclear.

Acknowledging the handbook confirms that you have read it and understand where to find the policies that apply to you. It is not a contract, and it doesn't replace the terms of your employment. Managers check that new team members complete the acknowledgement during their first week.